

Hagia Sophia

The great Byzantine basilica of Constantinople, converted into the city's principal mosque after the Ottoman Conquest



The basilica of Hagia Sophia ("Holy Wisdom") was commissioned by Justinian the Great, Eastern Roman emperor from 527 to 565 CE, to replace the church destroyed by rioting in Constantinople (present-day Istanbul). He imagined a building worthy of being the principal church of the Eastern Empire, and his architects accordingly presented him with a revolutionary plan—a square structure topped by an enormous dome. The building was completed in 537 CE, but its untested design, combined with poor construction methods, caused the dome to collapse just 20 years later. It was rebuilt with a slightly less shallow dome and more robust reinforcements, and it has survived in this form to the present day.

Church to mosque

The interior of the basilica was richly decorated in the Byzantine style with polished marble slabs and mosaics of Jesus and the saints on walls, ceiling, and floor. Hagia Sophia served as the central basilica of the Orthodox Church until the Ottoman conquest of Constantinople in 1453. Luckily, the Muslim invaders appreciated its architectural splendor and instead of destroying it set about converting it into a mosque, adding four minarets and installing a *mihrab* (a niche indicating the direction of Mecca) and a *minbar*, or pulpit. With the collapse of the Ottoman Empire and as part of Kemal Atatürk's secularization of Turkey, Hagia Sophia closed as a mosque in 1931 and reopened as a museum in 1935.

The **dome** of Hagia Sophia was the **biggest in the world** until surpassed by the **Duomo in Florence** in the 15th century



△ CROWNING THE CITYSCAPE

Adorned with its four minarets, the Byzantine basilica is a distinctive landmark that dominates the skyline of the historic peninsula of Istanbul.

◁ SPACE AND LIGHT

Hagia Sophia's square floor plan, high walls, and massive dome give the interior a sense of openness and light.

SUPPORTING THE DOME

In order to create the spacious nave of Hagia Sophia, the architects developed an innovative design, placing a circular dome on top of a square building. The weight of the dome is borne by four piers, which are disguised by pendentives—tapering triangular pillars forming elegant curved arches beneath the dome.

